

Editorial

The End Of Innocence

IT WAS JUST as well that the media did not name her. A news report carried by NDTV about a Delhi schoolgirl, whose obscene MMS is currently circulating amongst thousands of teenagers and adults across the country, is disturbing to say the least.

The schoolgirl (age and name not revealed) from Delhi Public School in the R K Puram area of south Delhi indulged in a sexual act with her boyfriend, who recorded it on his camera phone. The MMS, which obviously started from the boy's phone, soon spread like wildfire in Delhi, and later, the rest of the country.

Both the girl and the boy, along with eight others, were suspended from school for carrying camera phones to school.

But clearly, there is more than technology at work here. Technophobes would say it was the camera phone that was responsible for the "crime," and how technology empowers perverts to indulge in their wildest fantasies.

I disagree. It was the boy who was responsible. And his parents. Period.

I doubt whether the boy was aware of the ramifications of his sending the clip to a couple of friends. And I also doubt that the initial MMS was anything more than just an ego trip to show how he "scored" with his "girl." Just like it was for Francesca Willis, an Australian schoolgirl and model who recently posted provocative pictures of herself (shot using her school's Web cam) on her blog. The school sacked her, ensuring she became a national celebrity.

The Delhi case raises other questions—just how do you control the rampant misuse of technology; how do we stop children from playing excessively violent games; how do we stop them from becoming voyeurs; and most importantly, how do we stop them from using technology to become a tool of mistrust among even the closest of friends.

The answer is not to ban camera phones or pornography on the Web. Bans, like prohibition, just don't work. The answer here, as in most cases, is responsible parenting.

Parents I spoke to told me they need to be in touch with their children, and that therefore, they provide them with cell phones. Logically, if communication is the only issue, wouldn't a basic phone suffice?



Sachin Kalbag Executive Editor

“Bans on camera phones in schools do not work. The answer is responsible parenting”

Just as the personal video camera was developed to record life's events and not make porn movies, just as Photoshop was developed to give creativity an edge and not to morph faces on naked bodies, just as the Web was developed to share information and not for online fraud, so the camera phone was developed to store memories, and not betray your dear ones.

However, the human mind is a complex matrix. Technology's negative manifestations are not stored on a chip, but in the electric impulses that transmit information to the brain.

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